



Red-letter day: On April 2, 2015, Saina Nehwal scripted history by becoming the first Indian female badminton player — and just the second overall after Prakash Padukone in 1980 — to be ranked World No. 1. PTI

almost feels like someone else was playing those matches. I see myself and think, 'That can't be me!'

Do you think other players go through the same thing?

I think it's different for everyone. I was playing at the very highest level, and my life was pretty sorted. I was being called for events, was taken care of and had enough money to be comfortable. When I was playing, I didn't think so much about what was going to happen in the future. I was thinking about how I could improve as a player and what I had to achieve. Life was actually busy around that. I never thought about what would happen if I stopped tomorrow.

But these days I'm seeing a lot of struggle among players who didn't make it to that highest level. Not all of them have jobs. So I can't tell players anymore that you just play and everything will fall into place. If you look at cricket, they have made a system where, if you are in the top 50, you really don't have to worry

about finances. I think from 2021/2022 onwards, we saw a lot of badminton players who started realising that they couldn't just focus on their badminton. I saw a lot of them starting to put less focus on their badminton and focus on their studies. I also see that a lot of players, once they retire, start to go abroad as coaches. When Sai (Praneeth) went last year to the USA, he was making maybe seven or eight times more than what he would have made in India. I can't blame players. You have to do what makes sense to you.

Do you ever look back at matches and think I could have done this or won that?

Those wishes are never-ending. Sometimes I might think of the 2012 Olympic semis or when I was leading Carolina Marin during the opening game of the 2015 World Championships final. But I also look back and think I won 11 Super Series titles, a bronze medal at London, a bronze medal at the Asian Games, two World Championship medals, I was world number one, and a two-time gold medallist at the Commonwealth Games. Then it doesn't feel so bad.

It gets easier and easier to forget the difficult results. The only time I'll think about the All England loss to

Marin is when someone asks me about it. And it will stay in my head for an hour. But I'll still get to sleep that night. Others have it worse. I was just dominating a single All England match. Imagine what Lee Chong Wei, with three Olympic silver medals, must go through. He won 46 Super Series titles, but never won a single major world title. He lost matches to Lin Dan even when he held the match point. I once asked him, 'Lee, do you get sleep at night when you think of all the silver medals?' And he said, 'I have three kids now. Life goes on, and you stop thinking about these things.'

At what point in your career did you realise that things were going to be different after this particular injury?

I think the injury that changed things for me was the bone spurs I developed just before the Rio Olympics. I think my career was never the same after that. Ideally, if I had a trainer when I was starting out, I might have done a lot of things to prevent it. They might have told me that my hips, shin bones, ankles and lower back all needed to be strong. If I had done these things from time to time, this extra bone growth wouldn't have come.

It came because I pushed myself so hard. When you are playing extra on the court, you get a lot of osteophytes in your body. But that came as a surprise to me. I'd had injuries before, but these were things that I was able to recover from in a week or two at most.

So when the bone growths started developing, and the pain began, I thought I would push through it. I used to think I was blessed because I never picked up any major injuries like knee and ankle twists, which are very common in badminton. I thought I couldn't get hurt. But then, when I had that bone growth diagnosed a week before the Olympics, I didn't want to believe it was as bad as it was because I was in really good form. As a player, we just want to do well, and I'd done so well the previous year when I won a silver at the World